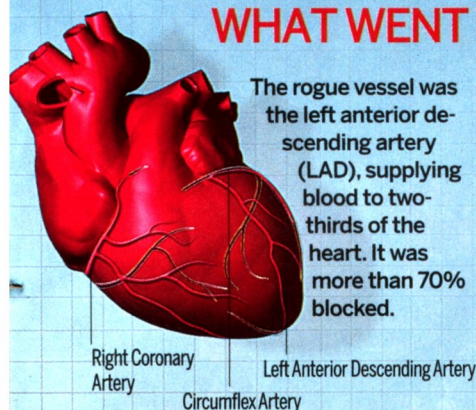


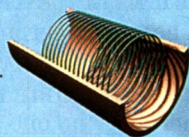
WHAT WENT WRONG?



The rogue vessel was the left anterior descending artery (LAD), supplying blood to two-thirds of the heart. It was more than 70% blocked.

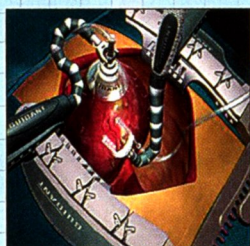


There was also a 50-60% blockage in the right coronary artery and the left circumflex artery.



Old stents (wire-mesh tubes to prop open arteries) had outlived their utility

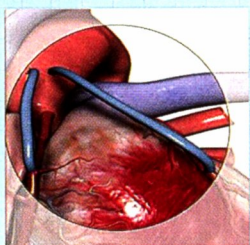
BEATING HEART



WHAT: The PM had a beating heart bypass, a new procedure during which the heart continues to beat and sustain blood circulation.

PROS: Lower risk of tissue damage, less risky than conventional bypass; faster recovery and better long-term option than angioplasty for serious heart patients, especially for diabetics

CONS: Invasive. Technically more complex because it was a repeat bypass for the PM.



SURGERY STATS

PM wheeled into OT: **6.40 a.m.**
Incision length: **7 inches** along the scar that marked the previous bypass

Surgery began at: **8 a.m.**

Surgery over at: **7.30 p.m.**

Wheeled into ICU at: **8.55 p.m.**

Blockages removed: **5**

Grafts (new routes to the heart) done: **5**

Blood vessels from where grafts were sourced:

Chest **1**, left hand **3**, left leg **1**

Road to RECOVERY

■ Recovery period might be 4 to 6 weeks

■ The PM taken off ventilator, out of ICU, IV lines removed, put on soft diet, talking, watching TV, sitting up on bed and has taken his first steps

■ Coughing—a reflex action of the body that expels excess fluid or particles from breathing passages—is being used as physiotherapy

■ The new grafts will last the PM the rest of his life

■ Doctors predict the surgery will enhance the quality of his life

duties which only the prime minister has performed for the past 60 years. For the first time, India had a Republic Day parade without the prime minister.

DAY OF THE UNEQUALS

It was expected that External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee, the senior-most Congressman in the Cabinet, would carry out the prime minister's duties. Instead, the old retainer of the Family was shown his place, which, to his shock, was not of the No. 2. He was just one of the unequals. "The prime minister left for the hospital in a good mood; till the last minute he was signing orders," said Prithviraj Chauhan, the minister of state in the PMO. Maybe he was secure in the knowledge that his job would remain intact. The vice-president was asked to give away bravery awards to children and Defence Minister A.K. Antony was told to perform the ceremonial duties. A mercilessly downsized Mukherjee was given the responsibilities of the Finance Ministry, a post he had held almost 25 years ago. And that left another aspirant adequately diminished: P. Chidambaram, the immediate ex-finance minister, who thought he would be presenting the vote of account in Parliament.

So what we have is more than a coalition government. It is a multipolar government. The standing order signed by the prime minister before he packed his Mirza Ghalib and left for AIMS merely stated that during his absence all the important decisions would be taken by the Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs (CCPA) presided over by the senior-most minister. But it was silent on the sensitive matter of who would press the nuclear button if a situation arose. The initial anxieties were removed when it was clarified that the political council, which is headed by the prime minister with some known and unknown members, would deal with such a scenario and the meeting would be chaired by the senior-most minister. Though Mukherjee cancelled most of his foreign trips scheduled over the next month, including one to Mauritius, he had to make an unexpected visit to Sri

RAM VILAS PASWAN, 62
Union Minister for Chemicals & Fertilisers and Steel
He underwent angioplasty to clear a blockage in the left anterior descending artery in 2005



P. R. DASMUNSI, 62
Union Minister
Had an angioplasty to clear two heart blockages last July. By October he was back in hospital with a complete left ventricular failure.